

justice can only be undone by a policy shift.

Indian corporations, multinationals and foreign vessels are the big fish which are vying for the catch of the decade within a year. The unscrupulous mining of sand against the Minor Minerals Act is bad news for sub-surface water and encroached land. It has a devastating impact on fish and fisheries. Whatever remains is killed by the chemical aquaculture polluting industries, which also make the fish inedible. All these can be checked through strict laws and environmental monitoring, provided the dilution of legal mandates, like the EIA Notification, 1994-2006, is stopped. The coasts are to be guarded, not merely by laws, but by the coastal security force of fish workers. Whatever projects are proposed must have their sanctions, contribution and right to planning and sharing in benefits.

Saving riverine and coastal eco-systems is not possible by the state alone. Let small communities and civil society groups, including local self-governments, take the lead and show the path. Asserting their rights under Article 243 of the Constitution, they can begin with mapping our own resources, harnessing programmes within the gram sabhas and



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Voice of India: People need to make themselves heard against the abuse of rivers and ecosystems

ward sabhas, with labour-intensive and suitable technology, including desilting ponds to small rivers, undertaking check dams to micro-watershed management, mangrove protection and plantation. All this is necessary to achieve the dream of a truly democratic and eco-sensitive development process without losing our invaluable rivers and priceless coastal heritage as well as the communities that thrive on, and protect, them.

The author is a social activist, known for her work in Narmada Bachao Andolan and convener of the National Alliance of People's Movement.



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